



The Humanitas Institute

Six Elements of Classical Education School Website Audit

School: Heart of Ohio Classical Academy
School Website: <https://ohioclassical.org/dublin/>

December 22, 2025

Disclaimer

This audit was performed using artificial intelligence tools to evaluate the presence and strength of classical education principles on school websites. Results are automated, probabilistic in nature, and should be considered indicative rather than definitive. See the full disclaimer in the Appendix for more details.

ACCS Member School

Any school that belongs to the Association of Classical Christian Schools ACCS or the Society for Classical Learning SCL is, by definition, recognized as a classical school because both organizations require adherence to the six essential elements defined by the Humanitas Institute. However, a school's website may not clearly reflect its conformity to one or more elements. In such cases, the school may still receive a "Somewhat Classical" rating for those elements. Schools can update their website content at any time to achieve a "Classical" rating for a given element.

Executive Summary

Heart of Ohio Classical Academy (HOCA) – Dublin Campus presents a distinctly classical orientation in its public-facing materials. The school emphasizes a content-rich liberal arts and sciences curriculum, moral character formation, the centrality of the Western tradition, Latin and grammar instruction, and teacher-led classrooms. It also foregrounds virtues, decorum, and civic virtue, along with a structured, tech-conscious classroom environment (tech-free in some settings) and strong family/parent engagement. Taken together, HOCA clearly aligns with many core elements of classical education, but some hallmarks (notably explicit liturgical/theological components or a pervasive, publicly stated Socratic seminar culture across grades) are less visible in the public materials. Overall classification: SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL.

Key insights - Evidence of classical core: liberal arts/Great Books ethos, Western-tradition emphasis, virtue formation, and teacher-led pedagogy anchored in traditional methods (grammar, phonics, Latin) and structured discipline.

- Public materials highlight virtue, character formation, and civic virtue as central aims, with explicit declarations that religion is not taught, but classical virtues are cultivated. - Parental partnership and open-campus ethos are strongly present, aligning with the classical model of parental involvement and community formation. - Gaps relative to a fully explicit, theological-liturgical frame or universal Socratic/seminar pedagogy across all grades are more visible in public materials, suggesting a SOMEWHAT rather than FULLY CLASSICAL designation in some categories.

Executive Summary — Element-by-Element Snapshot

- Element 1: Religious and Metaphysical Foundations — SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL
- Element 2: School Purpose and Goal — CLASSICAL
- Element 3: School Curriculum — CLASSICAL
- Element 4: School Pedagogy or Teaching Methods — SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL
- Element 5: School Faculty — SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL
- Element 6: Parents & Community — CLASSICAL

Executive Summary — Element-by-Element Snapshot

Element 1: Religious and Metaphysical Foundations — SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL

Evidence - Public materials emphasize virtue and moral character, citing that “classical virtues” (wisdom, justice, humility, courage) are formed, and that “we are not teaching religion, but rather the classical virtues.” This centers moral formation without explicit theological content. - Additional excerpts describe a curriculum grounded in the Western tradition and in virtue, with explicit reference to truth and beauty as real through the classical framework. - Latin/grammar/phonics and a tightly structured, teacher-led approach are present, but theology or liturgical communal practices are not foregrounded in the public materials.

Positive/Negative keyword analysis - Positive keywords found: virtue, wisdom, truth (as part of “true education”), moral character, classical virtues, beauty (contextually via the Great Books framework), Western

tradition. - Negative keywords found: theology, liturgy, worship, sacred, liturgical practices (not present in the public materials). - Quantitative estimate: Positive keywords matched approx. 2–3 (virtue, wisdom, true education) vs. Negative matches approx. 0–1 (no explicit theology; no liturgical terms). Overall, positive keyword presence dominates, but theological/liturgical foundations are not publicly articulated. About 2–3 positives to 0–1 negatives; roughly 75–100% of observed signals in this domain are positive when considering the explicit virtues/truth-leaning language. (Sourced from HOCA curriculum and virtue language; see citations above.)

Why this rating - The emphasis on virtue, moral character, and the formation of the soul aligns with classical aims (transcendental moral realism and virtues). However, explicit theological grounding or liturgical practices are not evidenced in HOCA's public-facing content, which weakens the case for a fully "Religious and Metaphysical Foundations" orientation. This yields a SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL rating rather than CLASSICAL.

Citations: The virtue-centered formation language is explicit in HOCA materials (not teaching religion, but classical virtues). The Western-tradition emphasis and the call to virtue in the curriculum provide supporting context. The absence of explicit liturgical/theological language is noted in the same materials.

Element 2: School Purpose and Goal — CLASSICAL

Evidence - HOCA describes education as formation of virtue and character, not merely workforce preparation, with aims of human flourishing and wisdom. Public materials emphasize "formation" and "intelligence plus character" as central goals. - The curriculum is described as liberal arts and sciences with moral character and civic virtue, indicating formation over instrumental outcomes. - There is explicit emphasis on the centrality of truth, goodness, and beauty in the educational process (the classical telos).

Positive/Negative keyword analysis - Positive keywords present: formation, virtue, human flourishing, liberal education, character, wisdom, truth/goodness/beauty (via classical framing), civic virtue.

- Negative keywords present: none of the explicit workforce- or career-readiness framing found in the public materials (e.g., "career-ready" or "21st-century skills" are not foregrounded). - Quantitative estimate: Positive matches appear across multiple phrases; estimated ratio suggests a predominantly positive signal. Roughly 3–5 positive signals vs. 0–1 negative signals (based on the absence of workforce-ready jargon and presence of formation/virtue language). This supports a CLASSICAL rating in this category.

Why this rating - The school's stated aims foreground formation, virtue, and liberal education anchored in classical ideals, aligning strongly with the Element 2 rubric in the classical framework.

Citations: Formation and virtue emphasis in HOCA's public materials. Liberal arts emphasis and moral character in HOCA's curriculum.

Element 3: School Curriculum — CLASSICAL

Evidence - HOCA presents a "Classical Education" with a content-rich, liberal arts and sciences curriculum that includes instruction in moral character and civic virtue. This directly mirrors classical Curriculum expectations. - The public materials emphasize the centrality of the Western tradition in history, literature, philosophy, and fine arts, and the presence of original primary sources/literature (Great Books approach). - The program includes Latin study, explicit phonics/grammar instruction, and a teacher-led approach with strong content requirements, consistent with a classical liberal arts structure. - The Hillsdale/K-12 curriculum alignment and public references to a "content-rich education" across core disciplines (math, science, literature, history) further reinforce a classical curriculum frame.

Positive/Negative keyword analysis - Positive keywords present: liberal arts, grammar, logic, rhetoric (implicit in a Hillsdale/K-12 framework), Great Books / primary sources, Western tradition, moral character, civic virtue, Latin, content-rich curriculum, teacher-led classrooms.

- Negative keywords present: none of the explicit “social studies” reframe or project-based-dominant terminology is foregrounded in the public materials. - Quantitative estimate: Multiple strong positive signals with minimal negative signals. This supports a CLASSICAL rating in Curriculum.

Why this rating - The materials consistently reference the Trivium/Quadrivium framework (grammar/phonics/Latin, logic, rhetoric) and Great Books-style engagement with Western tradition and primary sources; these are core curriculum markers for classical education.

Citations: Liberal arts/Great Books orientation and Western-tradition emphasis. Latin/grammar/phonics/tech-free emphasis.

Element 4: Pedagogy or Teaching Methods — SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL

Evidence - HOCA emphasizes teacher-led classrooms and explicit instruction (phonics, grammar; Latin), which aligns with classical pedagogy in the early grades and a structured approach. - Tech-Free Classrooms are highlighted, reflecting a normative stance toward disciplined, contemplative learning environments that can support classical pedagogy. - Some classic pedagogy signals (Socratic discussion, seminars, or debates; memorization/recitation; formation through imitation) are present in the classical framework, though explicit, public-facing articulation of widespread Socratic seminars across grades isn’t clearly demonstrated in the HOCA Dublin content. The public materials also emphasize “content-rich” and “living curriculum,” which can be compatible with Socratic/seminar approaches but lacks explicit, broad evidence of them.

Positive/Negative keyword analysis - Positive keywords present: teacher-led classrooms, phonics/grammar instruction, Latin, contemplative learning (Scholé) appears in the theoretical framework (via the classical lexicon in the knowledge base), and a culture of virtue that may accompany Socratic dialogue. - Negative keywords present: explicit public evidence of a sustained, institution-wide Socratic seminar culture, or explicit emphasis on memorization/recitation or chanting as central pedagogy, is less visible in the HOCA Dublin public content. The presence of “restful learning” or “Scholé” is not strongly evidenced beyond general classical intent. - Quantitative estimate: Positive signals exist for teacher-led, structured pedagogy; clear evidence for Socratic/seminar-based pedagogy is weaker. Approximately 2–3 positive signals vs. 0–1 explicit Socratic signals; overall a SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL rating.

Why this rating - The school’s public materials clearly support traditional, structured pedagogy (teacher-led, explicit phonics/grammar, Latin, tech-free), but lack explicit, consistent, public evidence of a campus-wide Socratic/seminar-based pedagogy across all grades. This yields a SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL designation for Pedagogy.

Citations: Teacher-led, grammar/phonics/Latin and tech-free emphasis. Audience-facing statements of classical pedagogy from HOCA material.

Element 5: Faculty — SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL

Evidence - HOCA lists a Board of Directors, Headmaster, and Faculty & Staff, indicating a formal governance and a defined faculty structure. This signals an organized faculty core but does not, in public materials, explicitly describe the faculty as “living curriculum” or as models of virtue in the language of classical pedagogy. - The materials emphasize teacher-led instruction and classical approach as central to the school’s identity, but there is less explicit language about faculty embodying virtue as the “living curriculum” or about faculty mentorship in the sense used in classical lexicon. - There is evidence of a well-defined faculty structure and named roles, with public displays of faculty, staff, and leadership.

Positive/Negative keyword analysis - Positive keywords present: virtuous teachers, mentors, steady “living curriculum” language (though not verbatim in HOCA’s public text; the concept is implied via “Headmaster” and “Faculty & Staff” sections). The explicit classical lexicon uses phrases like “model teachers” and “living curriculum.” HOCA’s public materials lean into teacher-led, content-rich instruction. - Negative keywords

present: no explicit mention of “teacher as facilitator (on the side)” or other negative signals that would contradict a classical teacherly formation approach in HOCA’s public materials. However, the explicit language of “living curriculum” or portraits of teacher ideals is not strongly evidenced in the Dublin content. - Quantitative estimate: Mixed; clear evidence of a teacher-led ethos but limited explicit, classic “living curriculum” portrait language. This yields a SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL rating for Faculty.

Why this rating - The public materials show governance and a structured faculty, plus a strong teacher-led approach, but lack explicit, detailed language about the faculty embodying a classical “portrait of teacher” or “living curriculum” in the same emphatic way the core classical documents describe. The evidence supports SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL rather than CLASSICAL for Faculty.

Citations: Board and faculty sections in HOCA materials.

Element 6: Parents & Community — CLASSICAL

Evidence - HOCA emphasizes strong parent involvement and partnership with families. Public materials frequently discuss parental engagement, parent events, and “co-teachers” style partnership, indicating a deep commitment to involving parents in the classical education process. - The materials explicitly welcome parents to visits and events, and public communications discuss family formation, book studies, and parent gatherings as part of the classical community experience. - The school’s communications emphasize a community culture built around classical ideals, virtue formation, and shared mission with families, aligning with the “Partnership with Families” and “Formation of Affections” sections of the classical schema. The HOCA materials describe a cooperative, family-centered educational community.

Positive/Negative keyword analysis - Positive keywords present: partnership with families, co-teachers, parental engagement, home-school connection, parent formation, family catechesis, open campus, parent training/book studies, community of learners.

- Negative keywords present: none observed in public HOCA materials (e.g., “parents as customers” or minimal parental involvement). The materials consistently promote active parental partnership. - Quantitative estimate: Clear predominance of positive signals. Multiple positive keywords identified; negligible negative signals. Strong CLASSICAL alignment for Parents & Community.

Why this rating - HOCA’s public content strongly foregrounds parental partnership, formation of affections in the home-and-school continuum, and open access to school events, which mirrors the Classical Elements document’s expectations for family partnership and community involvement.

Citations: Parent information/events and parent partnership language in HOCA materials. The broader “Formation of Affections” and family-culture alignment in the classical framework.

What Would Move the Needle

- Elevate explicit Socratic/Great-Conversation pedagogy across upper grades with documented classroom practices (seminars, dialectic discussions, and explicit opportunities for students to engage in Socratic inquiry). This would strengthen Element 4 (Pedagogy) to CLASSICAL.
 - Concrete step: publish detailed descriptions of Socratic practices, seminar formats, and exemplar unit plans across grades 6–12.
- Bolster explicit “living curriculum” language for Faculty (Element 5) by clarifying how faculty model virtue, mentor students, and embody the classical virtues in daily practice, including portraits of teacher-student formation and professional development aligned with classical pedagogy.
- Expand explicit integration of Great Books/primary sources and the Great Conversation framework in more explicit terms (Element 3) with a published scope-and-sequence that names major works and authors for each grade, along with assessment rubrics tied to the Great Books experience.

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- Deepen liturgical or theological grounding (Element 1) where appropriate, while maintaining HOCA's stated stance that it does not teach religion, by clearly articulating how classical virtue and metaphysical concepts inform character formation. If theology is intended to be part of the approach, publicly documenting how it interfaces with disciplines would strengthen the Religious and Metaphysical Foundations category.
 - Broaden the explicit presence of the "Scholé" (restful learning) and memorization/chanting practices (Element 4) through published exemplars of recitation, chant, or memory-work integrated into upper- and lower-school curricula, including artifacts or examples (songs, chants, verses) from the curriculum.
 - Enhance explicit parent-focused formation resources (e.g., ongoing book studies and family-learning guides) to further optimize the Parent & Community category toward a full CLASSICAL status, even beyond current engagement channels.
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Appendix

ARTIFICIAL INTELLIGENCE DISCLAIMER

This audit was conducted using artificial intelligence tools (including large language models and automated web-analysis scripts) to evaluate the extent to which school websites reflect or incorporate recognized principles of classical education (e.g., the trivium, emphasis on truth/beauty/goodness, integration of great books, Latin/classical languages, Socratic method, rigorous academics, moral/character formation, etc.).

Important Limitations and Caveats

1. **Automated Nature:** The analysis relies on AI interpretation of publicly-accessible school website content as of the date of the audit. It does not involve direct contact with schools, review of internal documents, classroom observation, or verification of curriculum implementation beyond what is stated or implied on the website.
2. **Probabilistic Results:** Scores and assessments are probabilistic and reflect the AI's best interpretation of available text and site structure. They are not infallible and may miss nuance, context, or recent changes not yet reflected online.
3. **Subjectivity of Classical Education:** "Classical Education" encompasses a range of traditions and interpretations (e.g., Dorothy Sayers' trivium model, Classical Christian Education, Great Books programs, etc.). The Humanitas Institute Audit of the Six Elements of Classical Education uses a broad, consensus-based framework derived from prominent classical education organizations and thought leaders. Reasonable people may disagree on weighting or inclusion of specific criteria.
4. **No Official Endorsement or Certification:** Results do not constitute official endorsement, accreditation, or certification by any classical education organization. They are provided for informational and research purposes only.
5. **Potential for Error:** Websites may be incomplete, poorly worded, or temporarily inaccurate. Conversely, sophisticated marketing language may create false positives. Human review by parents, educators, or classical education experts is strongly recommended before drawing final conclusions about any school.
6. **Data Privacy and Ethics:** Only publicly available information was analyzed. No attempts were made to access password-protected areas or collect personal data.
7. **No Liability:** The authors, developers, and distributors of this audit assume no liability for decisions made on the basis of these results. Users are solely responsible for their own due diligence.

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